letter waiting for him at the Institute for Space Studies, on CERN letterhead, from Bell himself.

“I think that the experiment you propose is of very high interest. I do not know of other relevant experiments that have been done,” Bell wrote. “In view of the general success of quantum mechanics, it is very hard for me to doubt the outcome of such experiments. However, I would prefer these experiments, in which the crucial concepts are very directly tested, to have been done and the results on record.” Bell, intimately familiar with the workings of quantum physics, knew that it was unlikely that the theory would be proven wrong. But he also knew better than to dash the obvious hopes of the young man who had written to him out of the blue. “Moreover,” his letter concluded, “there is always the slim chance of an unexpected result, which would shake the world!”

“The Vietnam War dominated the political thoughts of my generation,” Clauser wrote later. “Being a young student living in this era of revolutionary thinking, I naturally wanted to ‘shake the world!’” John Clauser’s mind was made up. He was going to perform the experiment—and, he hoped, prove quantum physics wrong.

On the other side of the Atlantic, a young German physicist named Dieter Zeh was having similar doubts about the Copenhagen interpretation. “It was a slow process, and not just a sudden thing,” he said later. “I always had these doubts, but of course I didn’t dare to draw the conclusion that these people are all nuts.” Thoughtful, humble, and unfailingly polite, Zeh had little in common with the loud and blustery Clauser, aside from a shared skepticism of Copenhagen. Clauser’s day-to-day work as an observational astrophysicist involved building and testing sensitive experimental equipment. Zeh, by contrast, was a theoretical nuclear physicist. His work involved detailed quantum calculations; he was very much at home with the abstract mathematics behind quantum physics. And these differences between the two men were also reflected in their ultimate aims. While Clauser was uncomfortable with quantum physics and wanted to prove it wrong in the laboratory, Zeh understood the theory intimately—and found